By the 1840s, rabbits had become a staple food in Australia, and were contained within stone enclosures. All this changed in 1859 when a settler, Thomas Austin, imported 12 pairs of European rabbits and released them on his estate near Geelong in Victoria. Twenty years later, rabbits had migrated to South Australia and Queensland, and then in the next two decades to Western Australia. By 1920, the rabbit population was 10 billion.

Rabbits appear to be innocuous creatures, but they have wreaked havoc on Australia's native species, competing with them for resources such as grass, herbs, roots, and seeds, and degrading the land. They become particularly troublesome during a drought, when they eat anything they can find in order to stay alive.

There have been several attempts to control the feral population, from rabbit-proof fences stretching more than 2,000 miles (3,200 km) to the more successful introduction of the myxoma virus and the rabbit calicivirus, in 1950 and 1995 respectively. The resulting disease has proved the most effective way of controlling their numbers and protecting native species.